

This China business

SOCIAL MEDIA HAS BEEN LIT UP BY WELL-MEANING, PATRIOTIC SOULS DEMANDING THAT EVERYONE "BOYCOTT CHINA", and all the while the country continues to sell out of Chinese-made products, because as the more prudent of users point out, "There is no option". And then, as usual, the comments section for everything, or Facebook as a whole, devolves into name calling and infighting.

We felt that between the extreme points of view, there is a space for India to grow, which we have to work towards. If we're ever going to be able to have this conversation, we need to shift the focus away from China and look at the capabilities of the rest of the world. Thus we arrived at a weird hypothetical scenario where China decides to take its ball and go home, leaving the rest of us standing there looking stupid. Now what happens? How does the world react? Given that everyone still wants to play ball, who will bring the new ball tomorrow? Who will manufacture it, who will handle it, who will decide the game we play with the ball, and most importantly, what will the teams look like? Who will play what part on the team, and how good will they be? In case you haven't already figured it out, we're using the analogy of the ball to represent technology and manufacturing of technology.

To be honest, we actually started thinking about this topic as a possible story when the COVID-19 pandemic began, and which is still an ongoing problem all these months later. China is often called the world's factory, and this is because it is merely a simple fact. More stuff is made in China than anywhere else in the world, and all of us own so much 'Made In China' stuff, that it would be easier to count what's not made in China than to count what is!

Although many of us are too young to have lived through the factory worker era of the world, it did happen for every country since the start of the industrial age. If there was one thing you could always count on, it was that there would be a strike happening somewhere in the world at any given time. Mass production tends to make everything an assembly line, and assembly lines breed discontent eventually. It used to feel like there was a constant power struggle between profits and wages, and when workers downed tools, all hell would break loose.

Today, we're in a situation that is precariously balanced on a razor blade of an edge. This is because the world's factory is not a company, it's a country. Companies are a lot easier to deal with, and have motives that are usually always profit driven, which makes them predictable. Countries, on the other hand, need not be driven by such practicality and are not as predictable. A company can just replace workers to meet their end goal, or fire their entire board of directors if it is publicly owned. Even Steve Jobs, if he desperately wanted to, would never be allowed to purposely bring Apple to a standstill. In fact, he got fired from running his own company! Countries are not companies though.

This is why we went down the route of imagining the worst, as a hypothetical scenario, and then proceed to let things play out and see how it affects the world, and more importantly to us, India. While there are a million things to consider, and so many variables that we are no doubt going to get a lot of things wrong (as would anyone!), we're going to try and simplify our lives and stick to the changes that will happen with respect to technology alone.

Long term readers of Digit know that we're apolitical, and as far as possible try and keep emotion out of our writing and bias out of our testing. This hypothetical scenario will play out in the same style, and focus only on the thing that brings all of us in the Digit family together – technology! However, we hope we get a lot of love and hate for starting this conversation. We're not averse to brickbats, we are actually far more scared of people being indifferent, because we're irrelevant. That would truly hurt!

Remember to write in and express yourself about this controversial topic, and allow this hypothetical scenario (or others?) play out in your head. We'd love to hear what you agree or disagree with us about. And where your imagination leads you...



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